SAM HORMUSJI FRAMJI JAMSHEDJI MANEKSHAW

1914–2008

SHFJ Manekshaw was a decorated military commander and the first Indian officer to be awarded the rank of Field Marshal. He was a charismatic leader known for his quick wit and direct manner, and was beloved by the men he commanded. Born into a Parsi family in Amritsar, he received his commission in 1934 and spent nearly forty years in the army. During this time, Manekshaw served in a variety of capacities but is best remembered for leading the Indian army during the war in East Pakistan (Bangladesh). Always plain-spoken, he opposed the Indian government's desire to go to war in April, suggesting that victory could be assured if the army had more time to prepare and avoided the monsoon. He was proven right when India defeated West Pakistan in December 1971.



As a young captain serving in Burma in World War II, Manekshaw was severely injured by machine-gun fire during a brave charge against the Japanese. He was not expected to survive, so a British major-general who was nearby pulled off his own Military Cross